

South American dancing

The dances of Central and South America reflect the cultures not only of the native peoples who have long occupied the region, but also of the European colonists and their African slaves. Many dances that originated in this region, such as the tango and samba, have become popular all over the world.

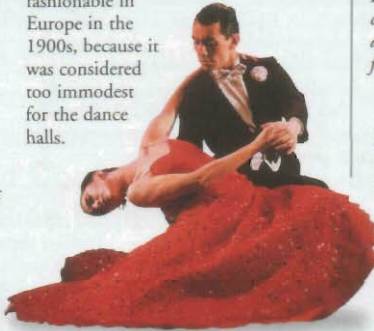


Macumba

The Macumba dance was taken to Brazil by African slaves as a form of voodoo-worship in which the dancer is believed to be possessed by a god. Macumba dancers worship Yemanjá, a goddess of the sea. Like all voodoo dances it involves shaking of the head and shoulders.

Tango

This dance originated in Argentina about 200 years ago. It had to be "cleaned up" before it became fashionable in Europe in the 1900s, because it was considered too immodest for the dance halls.



Contemporary dance

This style has no fixed technique. Dancers express their feelings in their movements. Contemporary dance began at the start of the 20th century, when US dancer Isadora Duncan broke away from ballet and developed her own style.



Samba

The samba was first danced in Brazil, especially at Carnival time, and became extremely popular in the United States and Europe in the early 1940s. It is danced by couples who perform simple backward and forward steps, swaying their bodies. In Brazil, there are many versions of the dance, each with a different rhythm, tempo, and mood.



Dancing the samba

Gene Kelly

American dancer Gene Kelly (1912–96) made film musicals popular with his athletic dance style. His best known films include *For Me and My Gal* (1942), *An American in Paris* (1951), and *Singin' in the Rain* (1952).



US dancer and actor Fred Astaire



Tap dance

In 19th-century America, black slaves combined African rhythms with the jigs of English and Irish settlers. Tap dance was thus created and became very popular.



Jazz dance

When jazz music became popular in the 1920s, an energetic, expressive form of dance developed with it. Today, jazz dancing is the main form of dancing in musicals and films.

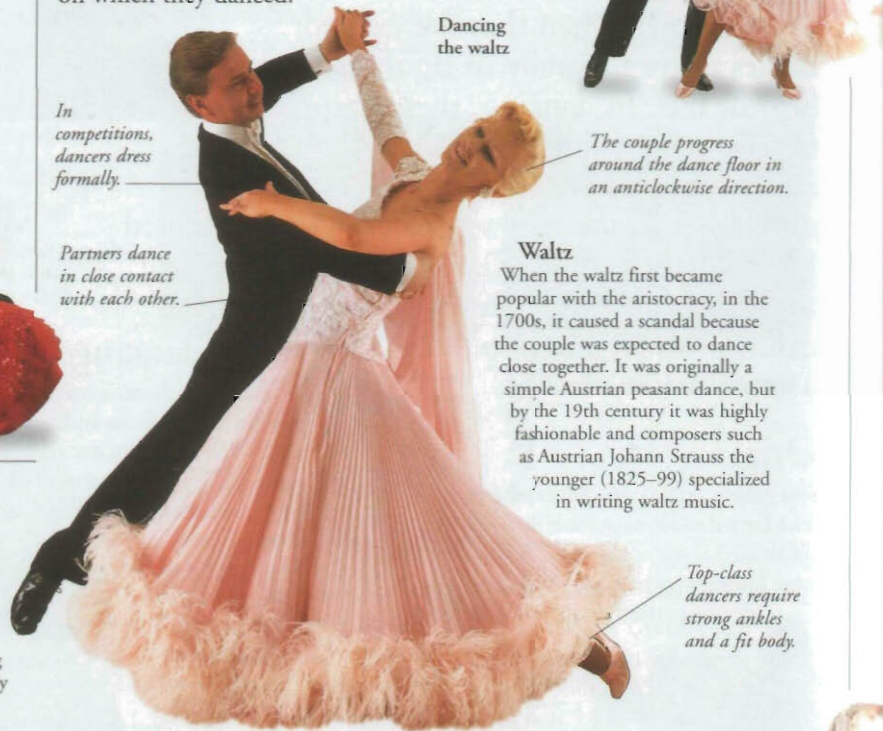
Disco

Disco dancing became popular in the 1970s. The name comes from the clubs called discotheques, in which records were played for dancing. Couples usually dance facing, but not touching, each other, using simple repetitive movements.



Ballroom dancing

Developed in the courts of Europe, many ballroom dances, such as the waltz and samba, were adapted from folk dances. They were danced on flat, polished floors, which allowed for elegant gliding movements, rather than the jumping and stamping which folk dancers developed to cope with the rough floors or grass on which they danced.



Dancing the waltz

In competitions, dancers dress formally.

Partners dance in close contact with each other.

The couple progress around the dance floor in an anticlockwise direction.

Waltz

When the waltz first became popular with the aristocracy, in the 1700s, it caused a scandal because the couple was expected to dance close together. It was originally a simple Austrian peasant dance, but by the 19th century it was highly fashionable and composers such as Austrian Johann Strauss the younger (1825–99) specialized in writing waltz music.

Top-class dancers require strong ankles and a fit body.

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